

or seven states produce enough wheat and rice that cater to the needs of the entire country. I think we have to give a serious thought about this and we have to see how we can improve on this. States not providing enough in terms of agricultural output need to introspect and come forward to willingly shoulder their responsibilities for ensuring a buoyant agricultural sector in the country. This would mean an investment in technology, improving the management of water and power for agriculture, convergence of resources at the farmer's end and creating sufficient infrastructure for marketing, warehousing and processing. Several initiatives of the Government of India like Rashtriya Krishi Vikas Yojana, National Food Security Mission, Macro Management of Agriculture, National Horticulture Mission, National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme, etc give an excellent opportunity to the states to leverage the funds available under these schemes to promote agricultural growth. What is important is innovation and convergence at the delivery point.

Resorting to frontier technologies is perhaps the only way to overcome the constraints of land and water for increasing production in the country. There are people who will question the efficacy of some of these technologies. In my opinion, closing our eyes to the latest developments in the world will be counter-productive given the size and aspirations of India's population. India, unlike many other countries, invests heavily in public-funded research. I have asked the Indian Council of Agricultural Research to leapfrog to frontier areas of research. This would give us the necessary technology interventions to enable us to ensure sustainable growth in agriculture. I also envisage a great role for the private sector in this field. Private investment in high technology areas in agriculture going hand-in-hand with public-funded research and public and state-funded seed production programmes will go a long way in taking agriculture to the next level in India.

Another area of concern is warehousing and marketing. To check the massive waste due to unscientific storage of foodgrain, we need to put in place an efficient supply chain for all our agriculture produce. I do realise that it is not possible for the Central and the state governments to fully address this issue in a short span of time, and therefore, here too, I see a great potential of involving the private sector in this process. Private investment in building the



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India has no good mechanism for marketing agricultural products. Foreign fruits and vegetables reach our cities easily whereas our own farmers living in remote villages are unable to market their products. I suggest we devise a mechanism between the Centre and the states so that our country makes a name for itself and our farmers also benefit. In terms of fertilisers, I feel we should also think about eco-friendly manure so that we can start producing organic foods. We are planning to make Sikkim the first organic state by 2015, along with helping it occupy the top spot in floriculture.

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value chains through warehouses, cold-chains and terminal markets will enable us to handle our agricultural produce in an efficient and hygienic manner. For this, many of the regulations on the agricultural marketing front would need a thorough overhaul and I am sure that most states would like to provide a better deal to farmers by removing the irritants and constraints in the regulatory frame-